Minister Andrei Gromyko, the consummate diplomat and a man that irritated Honecker the most. His condition was even more fragile when Honecker returned to Moscow for the twenty-fifth CPSU in February 1976, when Brezhnev gave the impression of a sick, elderly man who was only kept functioning with the help of medication. Although slowed by a cocktail of tranquilisers and sleeping pills, he did, though, have a few lucid moments and delivered a speech on the normalisation of relations between the Soviet Union and West Germany.12

For his part, Honecker gave one of the five speeches by the heads of socialist delegations on the second day of the congress. Although lavish in his praise of ties with the Soviet Union, trade links with Moscow were on the decline as the GDR continued to take out massive, short, medium and long-term loans in the West.13 Nevertheless, with growth slowing and the country increasingly reliant on imports, East Germany was encountering economic turbulence by early 1976.

After examining reams of data, economic experts Günter Mittag and Gerhard Schürer sent Honecker a devastating five-page report warning that eastern Germany would drift towards ‘ungovernability’ if the debt burden was increased (Schürer became the most direct and honest source on the failures of the economy but was also the most ignored). Willi Stoph – the harshest of economic hawks – was equally uncomfortable, as was Russian diplomat and economist Juli Alexandrovich Kwizinski. He remembered Honecker was impervious to the alarm signals being registered in diplomatic circles and recounted concerns about East Germany consuming more than it was able to produce, resulting in massive foreign debt, which under Ulbricht’s administration, had remained serviceable. ‘Soon, however, it turned out that almost the entire export growth of the GDR was used up to service the loans that had already been taken up,’ Kwizinski noted. ‘Many of the GDR’s economists sounded the alarm but no one in the Central Committee of the SED seemed to value their opinion.’14 A graphic illustration of the GDR’s trading patterns was revealed in Deutschen Aussenpolitik – a semi-state publication – which asserted that East German traffic with Comecon, the organisation facilitating trade and economic development of Eastern European countries belonging to the Soviet bloc, had slipped from 61 per cent in 1970 to 56 per cent in 1976.15